



SHARDA KANJAR, 35

The couple has nine daughters and three sons. Her last born daughter, named Sania, is younger than her four grandchildren but Sharda is happy with her brood.

than four children considering them as lost cases who could only be reined in through peer pressure." Not surprisingly, Bihar, Madhya Pradesh, Rajasthan, Uttar Pradesh and Orissa are projected to see their total population increase from 44.8 crore in 2001 to 59.28 crore in 2016. These are states with high birth rates and high infant mortality. Half the births in Bihar, Madhya Pradesh, Rajasthan and Uttar Pradesh are in families which have three or more children already. Sterilisation per 10,000 is lowest in Bihar at 110 with Uttar Pradesh (188), Rajasthan (447), and Madhya Pradesh (523) slightly better. In comparison, Tamil Nadu has 934 and Andhra Pradesh 1,230. Rajasthan has the highest total fertility rate after Bihar. The socio-economic impact is negative: the poor are adding more poor to the population.

In states like Rajasthan with a tradition of early marriage, half the

women in the state have had sexual intercourse by 17 and half the men by the time they are 20. This means that the child-bearing period of a woman's life in the state is far more than elsewhere as many continue to conceive beyond 40 years of age. The result is evident in the numbers: of the 1.43 crore married women in Rajasthan, 34 lakh have more than five children. Despite the fact that largely unproductive population is added by these families whose location is easy to identify, little official efforts have been made to focus on such groups. In the foothills of Mount Abu, Ganga Ram Rabari, 45, and his wife Naina Devi, have six children. The family has no land and depend on three cattle and NREGA to sustain

themselves. Yet, Rabari continues to believe that "children are the gift of God". In Jodhpur, two cobbler families say they have big families because everyone around them has one. Kesha Ram, a cobbler, and his wife Bhurki, 42, a ragpicker, earn Rs 160 a day and feeds eight children, two of whom are blind, including the eldest Gulab Rai, 26. Narendra Gupta of Prayas, an NGO working in Rajasthan says: "While the infant mortality rate has declined sharply, the total fertility rate has not, thus resulting in big families even today."

So, is there hope for a country with a billion plus population? Experts say there are indications that there will be a slight decline in the population growth in the next census but the fact is that the sample size of surveys like the National Family Health Survey are far too small to bring out any meaningful conclusions. Meanwhile, big families continue to, well, to get bigger. ■

“ We decided to leave out families with more than four children considering them as lost cases who could only be reined in through peer pressure. ”

S.D. GUPTA, Director, IIHMR